

Deduction: must, might & can't

CEFR B1

Lesson Pack · summary, worksheet & answer key

Quick answer

These modals show how certain you are about a present fact:

- 1 must = you're almost sure it's true (He must be rich).
- 2 might / may / could = it's possible (She might be busy).
- 3 can't = you're almost sure it's false (That can't be true).

This is 'deduction', not obligation. For the past, add have + past participle (must have been, can't have known).

At a glance

Modal	How sure	Example
must	almost certain it's true	He must be ill — he never misses work.
might / may / could	possible, not sure	She might be on her way.
can't	almost certain it's false	That can't be the right address.

Learning objectives

- Can use must, might/may/could and can't for present deductions (CEFR B1).
- Can distinguish deduction from obligation.
- Can extend deductions to the past with modal + have + participle.



Practice worksheet

Circle the correct option. Deduction: must, might & can't · CEFR B1

Name: _____

Date: _____

1. The lights are on and I can hear music. Someone ____ be home.

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|------------|-----------|
| A. must | B. can't |
| C. mustn't | D. should |

2. He's not answering. He ____ be asleep, but I'm not sure.

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|----------|------------|
| A. might | B. must |
| C. can't | D. mustn't |

3. That ____ be Sara — she's abroad this week.

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|----------|------------|
| A. can't | B. must |
| C. might | D. mustn't |

4. She's been working all night. She ____ be exhausted.

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| A. must | B. can't |
| C. mustn't | D. may not |

5. I'm not certain, but the keys ____ be in the car.

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|----------|------------|
| A. could | B. must |
| C. can't | D. mustn't |

6. He earns very little, so he ____ be rich.

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|----------|-----------|
| A. can't | B. must |
| C. might | D. should |

7. Choose the correct form: 'She ____ tired.'

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|---------------|---------------|
| A. must be | B. must to be |
| C. must being | D. must been |

8. Which modal means you're almost sure something is FALSE?

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|----------|----------|
| A. can't | B. must |
| C. might | D. could |

9. Correct this: 'That mustn't be the right answer.'

- | | |
|---|---|
| A. That can't be the right answer. | B. That mustn't to be the right answer. |
| C. That doesn't must be the right answer. | D. The sentence is already correct. |

10. Deduction differs from obligation because it shows...

- | | |
|--------------------------------------|----------------------------|
| A. how certain you are about a fact. | B. what the rules require. |
| C. what you are allowed to do. | D. what you prefer. |

Answer key

Correct answers with explanations · for the teacher

1. **A. must** — Strong evidence = 'must be home'.
2. **A. might** — An uncertain guess takes 'might be'.
3. **A. can't** — It's impossible, so 'can't be Sara'.
4. **A. must** — You're almost sure, so 'must be exhausted'.
5. **A. could** — A possibility takes 'could be'.
6. **A. can't** — The evidence says it's impossible: 'can't be rich'.
7. **A. must be** — Modal + be: 'must be tired'.
8. **A. can't** — 'Can't' = almost certain it's false.
9. **A. That can't be the right answer.** — A negative deduction takes 'can't be'.
10. **A. how certain you are about a fact.** — Deduction = how sure you are something is true or false.